△ BURSTING FORTH
Most current activity at Santa María consists of regular, often spectacular eruptions from the lava domes on its southern flank.

Santa María

A dangerous Central American volcano that produced the third largest eruption of the 20th century

Santa María is one of the most prominent of a chain of large volcanoes that rise high above the Pacific coastal plain of Guatemala. This chain is the result of the process of subduction as the Cocos oceanic plate slides beneath the Caribbean Plate. For much of recorded history, forest-covered Santa María has been quiet, but in October 1902, it erupted, tearing a huge crater in its southwestern flank and killing more than 5,000 people.

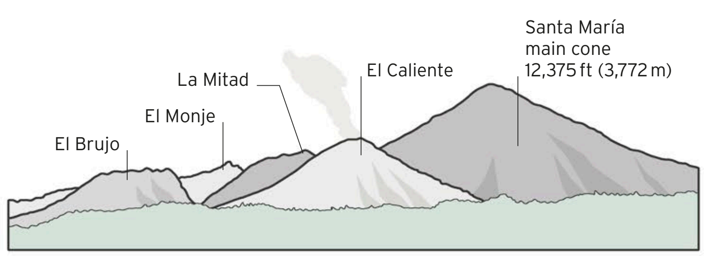
Activity today

In 1922, a lava dome—a huge, mound-shaped mass of gray lava—began growing in the massive flank crater formed in the 1902 eruption. This has since developed into a complex of four overlapping domes. Right up to the present day, frequent eruptions have occurred from these domes, sometimes generating dangerous pyroclastic flows (see panel, p.89) or blasting plumes of ash to heights of a couple of miles. Smaller explosions occur almost daily and can be viewed from the summit of Santa María's quieter main cone.

◁ DAWN VIEW
In this view at sunrise, Santa María's main volcanic cone, standing high in the background to the left, overlooks its group of dangerous lava domes.

SANTA MARÍA'S LAVA DOMES

Santa María's four lava domes, collectively known as the Santiaguito Complex, are called El Caliente ("the hot one"), La Mitad ("middle one"), El Monje ("the monk"), and El Brujo ("the sorcerer").



Santa María's **1902 eruption** produced about **1.3 cubic miles (5.4 cubic km)** of **ash and pumice**